



DESTINATION FILE

Kangaroo Island

Australia's premier wildlife island — and a powerful story of post-bushfire recovery.

COUNTRY

Nurrungai ·
Ngarrindjeri, SA

ACCESS

SeaLink ferry · 45 min

PAX RANKING

#2 of all destinations

STATUS

●Open · recovering

01 Destination overview

LOCATION & SIZE

112 km long, 57 km wide — Australia's third largest island, 13 km off the Fleurieu Peninsula. Around 4,405 km², resident population ~4,700. One-third is protected in national parks and conservation reserves.

CHARACTER

One of Australia's premier nature-based destinations — extraordinary wildlife, pristine beaches, artisan food and wine, and a powerful post-bushfire recovery story. The island separated from the mainland ~10,000 years ago, producing endemic wildlife found nowhere else on Earth.

ACCESS

SeaLink ferry from Cape Jervis (45 min) is the primary, preferred route — Cape Jervis is 90 min south of Adelaide. New ferries *Wanggami* and *Ruwi*, named in Ngarrindjeri, entered service in 2025. Regional Express (Rex) also flies Adelaide to Kingscote (KGC) daily.

BEST SEASON

Spring — wildflowers, whale calves, sea lion pups. **Summer** — peak, warm seas. **Autumn** — quiet, excellent wildlife. **Winter** — Southern Right Whales, few tourists, prime birdwatching.

GOVERNING BODIES

NPWS South Australia

KI Landscape Board

KI Council

Parks SA

LEGAL FRAMEWORKS

National Parks & Wildlife Act 1972 (SA)

EPBC Act 1999

Landscape SA Act 2019

02 Ngarrindjeri Traditional Owners

TRADITIONAL OWNERS

Kangaroo Island is **Nurrungau** to the Ngarrindjeri people — "the place of Nurrunderi," their revered creator. Their cultural, spiritual and ancestral connection to the island and its waters runs deep, and their knowledge of land, sea and sky informs conservation practice today.

KEY CULTURAL SITES

Remarkable Rocks — creation stories of Nurrunderi. **Admirals Arch** — spiritual significance. **Seal Bay** — Pungari, the seal, an ancient being. **Vivonne Bay** — the story of entering the Kalowinyeri, the spirit world.

CULTURAL RECOGNITION

SeaLink's ferries *Wanggami* and *Ruwi* were named with the Ngarrindjeri Aboriginal Council through a community competition — 1,500+ entries, formal NAC approval.

PRIORITY RECOMMENDATION

Include the Kangaroo Island Indigenous Day Tour (SeaLink + Kool Tours) in all KI itineraries. Led by Ngarrindjeri Elder Mark Koolmatrie — 2024 SA Tourism Hall of Fame inductee — it weaves cultural history with the bushfire recovery story.

03 Sustainability & current status

BLACK SUMMER BUSHFIRES • 2019-20

~48% of the island burned — over 210,000 hectares. More than 40,000 animals killed, two lives lost, and major tourism businesses including Southern Ocean Lodge destroyed.

RECOVERY — FIVE YEARS ON

Southern Ocean Lodge reopened in 2024. The \$19.5M Flinders Chase Visitor Centre opened the same year. The Wilderness Trail and Kelly Hill Conservation Park have reopened. Tourism hit a record year in 2023 and held strong through 2024.

CURRENT THREATS

Feral cats — the primary threat to endemic wildlife; 39 removed outside the Western River Refuge fence line in 2024 alone. **Invasive weeds** spreading through post-fire ground. **Climate change** lengthening fire seasons. **Visitor pressure** at key sites.

POSITIVE PROGRAMS

Western River Refuge — predator-free

2,709 ha protected

50,000 plants / year

Glossy Black-Cockatoo Recovery

\$8.7M DCCEEW recovery

BEFORE YOU SELL

Check Parks SA (parks.sa.gov.au) for trail or park closures before departure. The Wilderness Trail requires advance booking year-round.

04 Biodiversity & environment

WHY IT MATTERS

Separated from the mainland ~10,000 years ago, the island carries extraordinary endemism. Foxes and rabbits never established here, making it one of Australia's most intact ecological refuges.

KEY WILDLIFE

- Australian Sea Lions
- NZ Fur Seals
- Koalas
- Echidnas
- Little Penguins
- Southern Right Whales
- Leafy Sea Dragons
- 250+ birds

SPECIES TO KNOW

Glossy Black-Cockatoo

Endangered — 422 counted Sept 2024. The last refuge on Earth for this subspecies.

KI Dunnart

Critically endangered · **endemic** — found east of Flinders Chase for the first time in 40 years (2024).

Australian Sea Lion

Endangered — Seal Bay is the world's only fully accessible wild sea lion beach.

KI Southern Emu-wren

Endangered · **endemic** — severely hit by the 2019-20 fires.

Southern Right Whale

Protected — winter visitor, Jun-Oct. Keep 300 m clear.

WILDLIFE RULES

At Seal Bay, stay with the ranger and never approach, touch or block a sea lion's path to the water. Don't disturb Glossy Black-Cockatoo nesting areas at Baudin and Latham during breeding season, April-October.

05 Getting there sustainably

FERRY — RECOMMENDED

SeaLink from Cape Jervis to Penneshaw (45 min) is the most sustainable and scenic route. The 2025 vessels *Wanggami* and *Ruwi* are larger and more fuel-efficient than the boats they replaced.

BY AIR

Rex flies Adelaide to Kingscote (~30 min) — useful for tight itineraries or limited mobility, though the ferry is the richer, lower-carbon choice where time allows.

ON THE ISLAND

A hire car or guided tour is essential — there's no public transport. Guided tours (Exceptional KI, Kangaroo Island Odysseys, SeaLink) are the most sustainable option, consolidating movements and using local guides.

ROAD SAFETY — CRITICAL

Kangaroo Island has one of Australia's highest wildlife collision rates. Never drive at dawn, dusk or night, when kangaroos, wallabies and echidnas are active. Many hire agreements prohibit night driving — brief every client before departure.

06 Accessibility

OVERALL

Moderate and improving. Key wildlife experiences are accessible with planning; remote wilderness areas are not. The 2024 Flinders Chase Visitor Centre meets contemporary accessibility standards.

SEAL BAY

Boardwalk tours are wheelchair accessible. The beach-level walk crosses soft sand and is not. Book the boardwalk tour and notify Parks SA of requirements in advance.

REMARKABLE ROCKS

Accessible path from the car park to the viewing area; the granite itself is uneven and not wheelchair-suitable. The clifftop lookout is accessible with spectacular views.

FERRY

SeaLink ferries are accessible — arrange boarding assistance and accessible seating when booking. The 2025 vessels improved on previous facilities.

PLAN AHEAD

Facilities outside the main visitor sites are limited. Confirm specific requirements with each operator and Parks SA before booking any client with mobility needs.

07 Eco-certified operators

ACTIVITIES & TOURS

OJ supplier **Exceptional Kangaroo Island** — Advanced Ecotourism

OJ supplier **Kangaroo Island Ocean Safari** — Ecotourism

Kangaroo Island Outdoor Action — Advanced Ecotourism

Little Sahara Adventure Centre — Advanced Ecotourism

SOURCING & CURRENCY

Certified operators verified against the Ecotourism Australia register, April 2026. Listing shows current Orange Journeys suppliers plus other Advanced Ecotourism-certified operators at this destination. Confirm current certification status before booking — see ecotourism.org.au.

Sources — KI Landscape Board · Parks SA · Australian Wildlife Conservancy · BirdLife Australia · SeaLink South Australia · DCCEEW · Tourism SA · Flinders University. Reviewed at least every 12 months.
Orange Journeys · internal use only · June 2026